toilets scheme simply a renamed, repackaged mega-version of Manmohan Singh's Nirmal Bharat Scheme, rechristened Swachh Bharat? Just like the PMAY-G was a reworked version of what was once called the Indira Awas Yojana? Sure, he answered, but 'you people don't understand the real difference'. After Modi came to power, the money for these schemes 'comes directly into the labharthee's bank account, whether for toilets or for houses'. A villager wanting to get a toilet made, if eligible under Swachh Bharat, gets ₹12,000;[1] while those under the poverty line wanting a pucca house under PMAY-G get ₹1,20,000 in their bank account.[2] 'Imagine, if they got Rs 12,000 for fixing a toilet but it cost only Rs 5,000 to do it,' Chauhan said sardonically. 'The rest of the money is theirs.' The discussion had clearly hit a raw nerve. 'What if they just got some plastering done and got their name written on the list? Whether a toilet is made or not made, the money is with the labharthee. It's the same thing with the houses. People are getting a moti rakam [fat amount], Rs 1,20,000, to build a house. So much money may not be required.'[3] His heart seemed to be in the right place, but the pradhan was clearly not thrilled by the DBTs flowing into villagers' bank accounts. Yet, his micro-perspective had nailed the radical shift that such transfers had caused in the political economy of his village.

Earlier, villagers had to go with their 'arms outstretched' ('haath phaila ke') before local officials to get their entitlements, often for a large cut.[4] Now, the money came directly into their accounts. The officials could still demand a cut in return for sanctioning the payment, or if the villager wanted to be approved as a beneficiary for other schemes. But the fact that the money reached the beneficiary first increased his bargaining power. In a country where Rajiv Gandhi, as prime minister, had famously argued that only 15 paisa of every rupee that is spent on the poor actually reached them, DBTs, for all the faults in the system, drastically shifted the power dynamic in the village. Money went into bank accounts earlier too, but wily village pradhans could make fake job cards for schemes like the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS)—say fifty fake ones in a village of 200. Once Aadhaar cards were linked to bank accounts, this became much more difficult.